

continues right up to Rs. 7,000 or so. One vendor, who seemed to be better informed, or rather unbiased, told me to buy the Phenom II X2 550, if I wanted great performance, for just under Rs. 6,000. He (quite rightly) informed me that this CPU was better than the Intel Core 2 Duo E7xxx series that are similarly priced. He claimed AMDs problem used to be the lack of a stable platform, but with vendors like ASUS, Gigabyte and MSI making good, cheap AMD boards based on AMD's own platforms, this problem was solved and this guy recommended AMD to everyone looking to spend up to Rs. 7,000. I couldn't find anything more than dual cores for this price – it seems the prices of quad cores and tri-cores (AMD has those) have not fallen as much as I expected.

For 8,000 bucks or thereabouts, you can get a quad or tri-core processor. You can also pick up higher clocked, dual cores for the same price – more choices. In fact, Intel's E8400 (3 GHz) and Q8200 (2.33 GHz) are priced identically. I recommend the quad core in such cases – sure, the faster clocks on the dual core will affect some games positively, but for how long, given the drive for parallel processing. The Intel Q8400 (2.66 GHz), is also available for Rs. 8,500 – a scant 300 bucks more. I did see the Core i5 750 (2.66 GHz), priced at Rs. 11,000 with one guy, who told me it was a great CPU and people who had bought it were all praises. The major difference between this and the Core i7 CPU, is the presence of HT on the former, which is actually pretty useful as many applications utilise HT well.

When it comes to the high-end CPUs, I recommend Intel. AMD has heating problems with their high-end CPUs, particularly the Phenom II 955BE and 965BE.

Intel has no such problems, and although AMD now has the distinction of having the fastest clocked CPU, Intels Core i7 CPUs are faster at most applications. If you're looking for something around the Rs. 15,000 mark, I recommend the Core i7 920, look for the DO stepping, which runs very cool and has great overclocking headroom. This CPU is available for as little as Rs. 14,400, making it great value-for-money for those looking at a powerful, reasonably future-proof buy.

